

the flip side is that it requires you to accept the returns the market provides and trust that your assumptions based on the past will be true in the future. You are relying on markets to perform while you have no control over that performance. In a worst-case scenario, future returns may not match past returns. Even in a best-case scenario, it is unrealistic to assume returns will exceed the past. This means your upside is limited to 10 to 12 percent annualized average returns with a lot of variabilities.

Many people in the FI community love to talk about using high savings rates, index fund investing, and the 4% Rule as a pathway to a better life. You can get off the hamster wheel of spending thirty or forty years of trading time for money. For high earners, the simple path makes FI possible in a decade or less.

For others, the simple path can be defeating. Those with lower incomes, student loan debt, larger families, or other financial challenges hear about people saving 30 percent, 50 percent, even 80+ percent of their incomes and tune out quickly. It does no good to learn that a married couple can save over \$50,000 per year in tax-advantaged retirement accounts when your household is only bringing in \$40,000. Others have made mistakes in the stock market in the past and have no interest in jumping back in. Some on the